

Identifying when to use words or numerals

If a sentence begins with a number—even a very high number—the number should be written out in words, or the sentence should be rewritten to avoid starting with a number.

This sentence has been reworded and is the more successful version.

325 comets were discovered.

Sentences should never start with numerals.

Three hundred twenty-five comets were discovered.

This number has been written out because it is at the start of the sentence. This option is not ideal with longer numbers.

The aliens discovered **325** comets.

Roman numerals

Roman numerals use the letters *i* (one), *v* (five), *x* (10), *l* (50), *c* (100), *d* (500), and *m* (1,000) from the alphabet to represent numbers. Numbers over ten are a combination of these letters. Both upper- and lowercase Roman numerals are used to refer to acts and scenes in plays—for example, “Act IV, scene i.” Uppercase Roman numerals are sometimes used in names of royalty, such as “King Henry VIII.” Lowercase Roman numerals can be used for page references—for example, “xiv–xvii.”

If a lower Roman numeral is placed before a larger one, subtract it from the larger number, so *ix* is 10 (*x*) minus 1 (*i*) = 9.

Roman	Number	Roman	Number
I, i	1	XX, xx	20
II, ii	2	L, l	50
III, iii	3	C, c	100
IV, iv	4	CD, cd	400
V, v	5	CDX, cdx	410
VI, vi	6	D, d	500
VII, vii	7	CM, cm	900
VIII, viii	8	M, m	1,000
IX, ix	9	MCMXC	1,990
X, x	10	MMXIII	2,013

the aliens from planet Squark IV
2099, between 1:30 and 11:00 p.m.

Time

Numerals are usually used to write the time of day, with a colon separating the hour from the minutes. If expressing time in quarters or halves, or when using the phrase *o'clock*, the time should be written in words.

Between **1:30** and **11:00 p.m.**

time in numerals

time in words

Between **half past one** and **eleven o'clock.**

This abbreviation stands for “post meridiem” and refers to the afternoon.



• In numbers over a thousand, a **comma** is placed before every group of **three digits**, **except within addresses**—for example, **20,000** and **300,000**.

• When writing the time of day using the phrase ***o'clock***, **spell out** the number—for example, “**eleven o'clock.**”